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Title:
## Anxiety Versus You

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Publication Date: September 1, 2022

Published by
MUSHROOM CLOUD PRESS
U.S.A.

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# ANXIETY VERSUS YOU

A duo play

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Characters:

| | |
|---|---|
| SPEAKER: | The calm, cool, and collected cast member who is narrating the emotions and feelings of those that deal with anxiety. |
| ANXIETY: | The spastic and bombarding presence. Erratic and fidgety, jumping across the stage behind the speaker while shouting. Is a rollercoaster of emotion throughout. |

Synopsis:

Presented are 5 easy-to-follow coping mechanisms that are sure to help in the constant battle with the ever-annoying Anxiety.

ANXIETY VERSUS YOU

Scene 1

(SPEAKER stands CS serenely and addresses the audience directly. He/She is pleasant, with a relaxed demeanor.)

SPEAKER:

Anxiety. A condition that plagues young people all across America. An ever-growing epidemic that has stunted our social and professional growth.

(ANXIETY enters stage right at a hurried pace.)

ANXIETY:

Damn straight.

SPEAKER:

Now that we live in an ever-growing environment of social media comparisons, more options than we can imagine, and constant self-doubt, we are inundated with anxiety.

ANXIETY:

I’m like glitter after a toddler’s birthday, man. I’m everywhere!

SPEAKER:

And of course, we can recognize the symptoms of anxiety. Feeling restless, wound-up, or on edge.

ANXIETY:

(*moves stage left)* You got to move, son! You need to be getting your butt in gear, ya hear?

SPEAKER:

Having difficulty concentrating or your mind going blank.

ANXIETY:

Two plus two equals...chair! I know I heard words out of her mouth...she said...Oh look, a squirrel! What was I saying?

SPEAKER:

Having feelings of worry and difficulty controlling emotions.

ANXIETY:

Nobody likes you. Everyone hates you. They think you smell. They think you smell like hot tuna in a baby's diaper! (*Begins to cry)* Why can't I just be like...everyone...else! *(Now angry)* Who the hell do those mo-fos think they are!

SPEAKER:

And of course, difficulty sleeping at night...which can exacerbate all of the symptoms already mentioned.

ANXIETY:

(*moves stage right)* Did I study enough for that test? What if I forget? What if I go blank? What if I fall asleep during the test? What if I wake up naked during the test? What if my crush laughs at me? What if I...Damn! Why can't I sleep!

SPEAKER:

You get the idea. So here's the bad news...you can't cure anxiety.

ANXIETY:

Damn! I'm like herpes.

SPEAKER:

Correct. But just like genital herpes, you can learn to live with and cope with your anxiety, which is what I'm here for today. These are 5 things you can do in order to cope with your annoying anxiety.

ANXIETY:

Well, get after it, Dr. Phil!

SPEAKER:

The first tip is pretty simple. Breathe.

ANXIETY:

Like this?

(ANXIETY quickly inhales and exhales at a rapid pace, loud and panicky)

SPEAKER:

No, not like that. Breathing like that will actually make your body feel worse, which will in turn worsen your anxiety.

ANXIETY:

Ah, hell!

SPEAKER:

What you need to do instead is change up your breathing. The most common method is the 4-7-8 method. You inhale for four seconds. Then hold your breath for seven seconds. And finally, you exhale for 8 seconds.

ANXIETY:

Do I Mississippi?

SPEAKER:

No, because that could kill you. Or at least cause you more stress. There is a reason that when your plane is crashing the oxygen masks fall from the ceiling. Breathing is a natural way for your body to regulate itself. So by changing your breathing to slow and steady breaths, you're also relaxing in the process. Therefore, reducing anxiety. This can help at the moment that you're feeling anxiety and also at night when you're trying to relax to sleep.

(ANXIETY'S face is turning red. SPEAKER notices)

SPEAKER:

What are you doing?

ANXIETY:

(*Gasps for air)* I Mississippied.

SPEAKER:

Anyways. The next thing you can do is meditate.

ANXIETY:

Like saying a bunch of ‘ohms’ and what not?

SPEAKER:

I mean, not really. Meditation is simply taking a moment to focus on your breathing and block out the noise from the rest of the world. (*closes eyes)*

ANXIETY:

(*right in SPEAKER’s ear)* Hey. Hey. Hey. Listen. Listen. I gotta ask you something. Hey. Hey. Look at that dog right there. Look at that guy in the front row. He’s laughing like you’re an idiot. I know you’re listening. Stop ignoring me. I’m talking to you. Oh, I see how it is. I see how it is.

SPEAKER:

(*opens eyes)* Meditation gives you the opportunity to think about your thought process and address what is stressing you out. It’s also important to be able to stop and think about your emotions before you give into them and do something you will regret.

ANXIETY:

Like murder?

SPEAKER:

Yeah, like that. Meditation is also beneficial against heart disease, depression, and high blood pressure.

ANXIETY:

But you look like a damn fool!

SPEAKER:

Is that the worst thing that can happen? Which is a perfect segue into my next tip.

ANXIETY:

Damn! I hate being helpful.

SPEAKER:

This is going to seem counterintuitive, but I promise it'll help. Take whatever it is that you're stressed about and imagine the worst possible scenario happening. It's called Negative Visualization. Imagine everything going wrong. What's the worst that could happen?

ANXIETY:
(*pacing behind SPEAKER)* The apocalypse! Nuclear war! Genocide! Barack and Michelle Obama splitting up!

SPEAKER:
Relax. Unless you're God, a world leader, or one of the Obamas, chances are none of that is going to happen. So in order to cope with your anxiety of possible failure, you have to imagine failing and be okay with it. I'll repeat that. It's okay to fail. Your life will not be over. The world will keep spinning. The sun will come out tomorrow. And the Obamas will outshine every other married couple on the planet.

ANXIETY:
But I'll be a failure!

SPEAKER:
You say that like it's a bad thing. Thomas Edison made a thousand unsuccessful attempts before inventing the lightbulb.

ANXIETY:
He doesn't sound too bright...get it?

SPEAKER:
12 publishers rejected J.K. Rowling's first Harry Potter manuscript.

ANXIETY:
Maybe they didn't see the magic.

SPEAKER:
Even Michael Jordan said, "I've missed more than 9,000 shots in my career. I've lost almost 300 games. Twenty-six times I've been trusted to take the game-winning shot and missed. I've

failed over and over and over again in my life. And that is why I succeed.”

ANXIETY:

I mean, he’s no Lebron…

SPEAKER:

You shut your mouth.

ANXIETY:

But what if I’m just worried about what other people are going to think of me?

SPEAKER:

Dude, nobody else cares. That’s tip number four by the way. Nobody cares. You’re the one who is responsible for your emotions and you’re the only one having your emotions. No one else is paying attention to you more than you’re paying attention to yourself. So when you’re feeling stressed and anxious, remind yourself that nobody cares. No one is watching you. No one is keeping tabs on if you succeed or fail. You’re the one holding yourself to such a high standard.

ANXIETY:

What about my mom?

SPEAKER:

Well, unless you’re a doctor, nothing is going to please her.

ANXIETY:

What about my grandma?

SPEAKER:

Please, you could’ve assassinated Lincoln and your grandma would still bake you cookies and send you five dollars on your birthday. The final and probably the most important tip is...well...talk to someone.

ANXIETY:

Like a shrink?

SPEAKER:
I mean, not necessarily. Just talk to, you know, a person. A friend. An acquaintance.

ANXIETY:
What about a stranger?

SPEAKER:
Let’s not cause anyone else anxiety. Look, whenever we’re an island unto ourselves, our thoughts become exaggerated and built up in our heads. Whether it’s the fear of failure or even doing something embarrassing in front of people, we can escalate it in our minds and increase our anxiety, turning little things into huge problems. For instance, let’s say that Janet didn’t smile at you in the hallway or something.

ANXIETY:
Janet didn’t smile at me in the hallway? It must mean she doesn’t like me. Why doesn’t she like me? Do other people not like me? Is there a reason they don’t like me? Is there some flaw about me that is causing them not to like me? Oh God, how long has this been going on? Do they know something I don’t? Am I going to get kicked out of school? Get fired? Will no one be my friend? Will no one be my boyfriend/girlfriend? Am I going to be alone forever? Am I going to have thirty-six cats and knit them sweaters because I have nothing else in my life?

SPEAKER:
Chill, man. Janet doesn’t smile at anyone.

ANXIETY:
Oh...yeah.

SPEAKER:
See? By just talking to someone and sharing your thoughts, you’re able to gain a different perspective or understanding. You’ll realize that you’re not alone because Janet is stuck-up and doesn’t smile at anyone. If you embarrass yourself, talk about it with someone else. Chances are they will have experienced the same thing and guess what, they’re just fine.

And you will be too. Suddenly the thing that you were panicking about is now something to laugh at with someone else.

ANXIETY:

(*laughing)* Aw, man, you're so right. Janet is totally full of herself.

SPEAKER:

Says the guy/girl who thought his/her failure was going to cause the Obamas to break up.

ANXIETY:

Hey! (*begins moving upstage)*

SPEAKER:

Look, there's no cure for anxiety, but that doesn't mean it needs to control your life. In fact, anxiety is a necessary part of life. It's a natural feeling that our bodies developed in order to warn us of approaching dangers. It's not a bad thing. No feeling is good or bad. It all depends on how we react to them. By training yourself to cope with your anxiety, it will help you in the future by training your body to deal with stress before it even becomes a problem. Just like our muscles have a thing called muscle memory, our brains kind of have the same thing with our feelings. So no, our anxiety will never be gone, but we can work on reducing its effect and making its voice a little harder to hear.

ANXIETY:

(*From upstage, voice fainter)* Hey, can you hear me? I'm talking here! I'm still back here!

SPEAKER:

And it can stay back there. When it comes to a battle between anxiety and you, by learning how to cope, you always win.

END SCENE